The Witches

By Roald Dahl

CHILD: *(to audience)* I had two separate encounters with witches before I was eight years old. From the first I escaped unharmed, but on the second occasion I was not so lucky. The fact that I am still here and able to speak to you is due entirely to my wonderful grandmother.

INTRODUCTION

You see, according to Grandmother, a REAL WITCH gets the same pleasure from squelching a child as you get from eating a plateful of strawberries and cream. They plot to do away with one child a week.

(In a witchy voice) "One Child a Week is 52 a year . . . Squish them and squiggle them and make them disappear."

That is the motto of all witches. And I know this because my Grandma taught me about . . . The Witches by Roald Dahl

GRANDMOTHER: (My Grandmother) My darling, you won't last long in this world if you don't know how to spot a witch when you see one. You must remember everything I tell you. After that, all you can do is cross your heart and hope for the best. I have known no less than five children who have simply vanished off the face of this earth, never to be seen again. The witches took them. The first child I knew who disappeared was called Ranghild Hansen. Ranghild was about eight at the time and was playing with her little sister on the lawn. Their mother, who was baking bread in the kitchen, came outside for a breath of air.

MOTHER: Where's Ranghild?

SISTER: She went away with the tall lady in white gloves. She took Ranghild by the hand and led her away.

GRANDMA: No one ever saw Ranghild again.

CHILD: What happened to the other four children?

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GRANDMA: The second one was very peculiar. There was a family called Christiansen and they had an old oil-painting in the living-room. There were no people in the painting, just a flock of ducks on a grassy farmyard and a farmhouse in the background. Well, one day their daughter Solveg came home from school eating an apple. She said a nice lady had given it to her on the street. The next morning little Solveg was not in her bed. The parents searched everywhere but they couldn't find her. Then all of a sudden, her father shouted . . .

FATHER: There she is! That's Solveg feeding the ducks!

GRANDMA: He was pointing at the oil-painting. Solveg was standing in the farmyard throwing bread to the ducks. She was just a picture painted on the canvas.

CHILD: Did ***you*** ever see that painting, Grandmamma, with the little girl in it?

GRANDMA: Many times. And the peculiar thing was that little Solveg kept changing her position in the picture. One day she would be inside the farmhouse, and you could see her face looking out of the window. Another day she would be far over to the left with a duck in her arms. And what was most odd of all was that as the years went by; she kept growing older. In ten years, the small girl had become a young woman. In thirty years, she was middle-aged. Then all at once, fifty-four years after it all happened, she disappeared from the picture altogether.

CHILD: You mean she died? . . . *(gulps and gathers the courage to hear another)* What happened to the third one?"

GRANDMA: The third one was little Birgit Svenson. One day she started growing feathers all over her body. Within a month, she had turned into a large white chicken. Her parents kept her for years in a pen in the garden. She even laid eggs.

CHILD: What happened to the fourth child?

GRANDMA: The fourth was a boy called Harald. One morning his skin went all greyish-yellow. Then it became hard and crackly, like the shell of a nut. By evening, the boy had turned to stone. I'll take you to see him if you like. He stands in the hall, a little stone statue. Visitors lean their umbrellas up against him.

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CHILD: *(to audience)* Although I was very young, I was not prepared to believe everything my grandmother told me. And yet she spoke with such conviction and with never a smile on her face or a twinkle in her eye, that I found myself beginning to wonder. *(to Grandma)* Go on, Grandmamma. You told me there were five.

GRANDMA: Number five was rather an interesting case. A nine-year-old boy called Leif was summer-holidaying with his family on one of those little islands. Young Leif dived into the water and his father noticed that he stayed under an unusually long time. When he came to the surface at last, he wasn't Leif anymore. He was a porpoise.

CHILD: He wasn't! He couldn't have been!

GRANDMA: Absolutely. I knew his mother well. She told me how Leif the Porpoise stayed with them all that afternoon giving his brothers and sisters rides on his back. They had a wonderful time. Then he waved a flipper at them and swam away, never to be seen again.

CHILD: But wasn't there a most tremendous fuss when this happened?

GRANDMA: Not much. You must remember here in Norway we are used to that sort of thing. There are witches everywhere. There's probably one living in our street this very moment. It's time you went to bed.

CHILD: A witch wouldn't come in through my window in the night, would she?

GRANDMA: No, a witch will never do silly things like climbing up drainpipes or breaking into people's houses. **(How to Recognize a Witch)** But tonight, I am going to tell you how to recognize a witch when you see one.

CHILD: Can you always be sure?

GRANDMA: No, you can't. And that's the trouble. In the first place, a REAL WITCH is certain always to be wearing gloves when you meet her. Do you want to know why . . . because she doesn't have fingernails. Instead of fingernails, she has claws, like a cat, and she wears the gloves to hide them. Mind you, lots of very respectable women wear gloves, so this doesn't help you very much.

CHILD: *(with great fear)* Mamma used to wear gloves.

GRANDMA: The second thing to remember is that a REAL WITCH is always bald.

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CHILD: *Bald!*

GRANDMA: Bald as a boiled egg

CHILD: *(to audience)* I was shocked. There was something indecent about a bald woman. *(to Grandma with bravado)* If she's bald, she'll be easy to spot.

GRANDMA: Not at all, A REAL WITCH always wears a first-class wig. And it is almost impossible to tell a first-class wig from ordinary hair unless you give it a pull to see if it comes off.

CHILD: What other things must I look for to recognize a witch?

GRANDMA: Look for the nose-holes. Witches have larger nose-holes than ordinary people. A REAL WITCH has the most amazing powers of smell. She can actually smell out a child who is standing on the other side of the street on a pitch-black night.

CHILD: She couldn't smell me. I've just had a bath.

GRANDMA: A clean child gives off the most ghastly stench to a witch. The dirtier you are, the less you smell. The smell that drives a witch mad actually comes oozing out of your skin in waves. Stink-waves the witches call them, go floating through the air and hit the witch smack in her nostrils. They send her reeling. When you haven't washed for a week and your skin is all covered with dirt, then the stink-waves cannot come oozing out nearly so strongly.

CHILD: I shall never have a bath again! Tell me what else to look for in a witch.

GRANDMA: The eyes. The eyes of a REAL WITCH are different from yours and mine. Look in the middle of each eye where there is normally a little black dot. If she is a witch, the black dot will keep changing colour, and you will see fire and you will see ice dancing right in the very centre of the coloured dot. It will send shivers running all over your skin.

CHILD: *(to audience)* My grandmother leant back in her chair and I stared at her, fascinated. She was not smiling. She looked deadly serious. *(to Grandma)* Are there other things?

GRANDMA: Of course. You don't seem to understand that witches are not actually women at all. They ***look*** like, ***talk*** like and are able to ***act*** like women. But in fact they are demons in human shape. You can never be sure whether a woman is a witch or not just by looking at her. But if she is wearing the gloves, has the large nose-holes, queer eyes and hair that looks as though it might be a wig -- then you run like mad.

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CHILD: Grandmamma, when you were a little girl, did *you* ever meet a witch?

GRANDMA: I'm not going to tell you. It would frighten you out of your skin and give you bad dreams. Certain things are too horrible to talk about.

CHILD: Does it have something to do with your missing thumb? *(to audience)* Suddenly, her old, wrinkled lips shut tight as a pair of tongs and the hand which had no thumb on it began to quiver very slightly. She didn't look at me. She didn't speak. She didn't move . . . It must have been something absolutely appalling and gruesome.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

2005 National Qualifier
2008 National Qualifier
2016 National Qualifier
2019 National Qualifier
2021 National Qualifier
2021 National Qualifier – MS
2022 National Qualifier – MS
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